

KEY FIGURES

TARIQUE RAHMAN, 60

- Chairman of BNP; central figure of the anti-Awami League opposition mainstream, son of the late former PM Khaleda Zia
- Contesting from two seats: Dhaka 17 and Bogura 6
- Campaigning after 17 years of exile; presented as the BNP's PM candidate; polls show substantial public support
- Frames himself as the "order and stability" candidate; offers to fix unemployment, poverty etc.
- Under Hasina's rule, he faced multiple corruption charges



DR SHAFIQUR RAHMAN, 67

- Leader of the once banned Bangladesh Jamaat-e-Islami. An old ally of BNP, Jel represents the Islamist bloc now aiming for power
- Contesting from Dhaka 15 seat
- Has faced backlash for provocative social media remarks (for example, on women) that energise hardliners and alarm moderates and minorities
- Offers corruption-free, business-friendly environment
- Carries baggage of being anti-independence—Jel had resisted the Bangladesh liberation war of 1971



NAHID ISLAM, 27

- Young activist-convenor of the National Citizen Party (NCP) that emerged from the student-led protests of July-August 2024. Served as advisor in the interim government
- Contesting from the Dhaka 11 seat; in all, NCP is contesting 30 seats
- Face of the student movement; has credibility with young voters; promises to create 10 million jobs
- Attempts to position NCP as a new centrist force did not take off; his decision to forge electoral alliance with Jel led to an exodus from the party and boycott of polls, especially of women leaders

INFLUENCERS



MUHAMMAD YUNUS, 85

- Nobel laureate who was appointed chief adviser of the interim government in August 2024
- Launched reform commissions, 'de-Indianised' foreign policy, banned Awami League, lifted ban on Jel
- His administration's alleged crackdowns on political rivals, failure to uphold law and order and curb violence against minorities are central election flashpoints



SHEIKH HASINA, 78

- Awami League leader and former PM currently in exile in India and the focal figure of the pre-2024 order
- Her party's exclusion from the polls, her questioning the election's legitimacy and her calls for "free, fair and inclusive" polls make Hasina a live factor for millions of supporters

1,967

Total number of candidates. BNP to contest 285 seats; Jel has candidates in 243 constituencies; National Citizen Party (NCP) will contest 30 seats